How to Pass Cognitive and Game-Based Assessments

Most large banks, asset managers and buyside firms now run a game-based test (pymetrics, HireVue Games, SHL) before anyone reads your resume. It is not a knowledge test. It is 12 short games, about 25 to 30 minutes, that measure traits like attention, risk calibration, effort, planning, memory and emotion recognition, then compare your profile to the people already succeeding in that role. You cannot study for it, but you can absolutely blow it, and most people who do fail for avoidable reasons.

Know each game before you sit down

- **Balloon game.** Pump for money and cash out before it pops. Tests risk calibration, not caution. Learn the pop pattern and be consistent. How much risk is wanted depends on the role (see below).
- **Stop signal / keypress.** Press on the go signal, never on the stop signal. Accuracy beats speed.
- **Digit memory / n-back.** Recall the sequence. Stay locked in and do not guess wildly. Tests working memory and focus.
- **Tower game.** Plan the full sequence of moves before you touch anything. Fewer moves scores higher than fast moves.
- **Cards game.** Find which decks pay and stick with them. Tests learning from feedback rather than chasing losses.
- **Money exchange games.** Be reasonably generous and expect fairness back, but do not get taken repeatedly. Tests trust and altruism.
- **Faces / emotion game.** Just be accurate. Take the extra second if you need it.

Different roles want different traits

Traits are scored on a spectrum and neither end is universally bad. The firm matches you against a profile built from its own top performers in that seat, so the same behavior can help you at one desk and hurt you at another. Broadly:

- **Investment banking.** Effort and persistence, attention to detail, planning, and steady focus under time pressure. Moderate risk tolerance. Diligence matters more than boldness, so do not chase big balloon payouts at the expense of consistency.
- **Sales and trading.** Fast, accurate decisions, higher risk tolerance that is still calibrated, quick learning from feedback, and emotional control. Speed counts here more than anywhere else, but impulsive presses on the stop signal game still hurt.
- **Private equity and private credit.** Planning and patience, learning from feedback, decisiveness once the picture is clear, moderate risk. Credit leans a notch more risk averse than PE. Tower and cards games carry the most weight.
- **Asset management and research.** Patience, attention, consistency and a longer learning horizon. Moderate to lower risk tolerance. Erratic play reads worse here than a conservative profile does.
- **Wealth management and client-facing roles.** Emotion recognition, trust and fairness. The faces and money exchange games matter most, and a reading toward generous and perceptive is a plus rather than a flaw.

Across every role, play like a sharp version of yourself and do not act out a persona. Inconsistent behavior across games produces a noisy profile, and a noisy profile gets flagged faster than an average one.

Preparation that actually moves the needle

1. Do one or two full practice runs so no game surprises you. Free versions of most games exist at gameassessmentprep.com and paid simulations at jobtestprep.com. More than two runs has little return since the traits themselves do not change.
2. Read every game's instructions completely. Games cannot be replayed, and a misread instruction is the most common way strong candidates tank a section.
3. Laptop with a mouse, never a phone or trackpad. Stable wifi, quiet room, no notifications.
4. Rested and calm. Reaction time games punish fatigue and caffeine jitters. Do not take it late at night after studying.
5. Check whether you already have a recent pymetrics result. Scores are shared across firms on the platform, so you may not need to retake it, and a strong past result carries over.

Keep it in perspective

This round has a wide pass band. It mostly screens out inattentive or erratic candidates, not strong ones. The rounds that decide your offer are the video interview and the technicals that follow. Spend one evening here, then get back to accounting, valuation, markets and your story.